

the seller's property disclosure statement, ask how old the appliances, systems, roof, windows, and siding are.

Here's another fun one: Google the address. Did your home make the news? Was there an event, positive or negative? (Scott once bought a fourplex in which a shooting had taken place. He bought it anyway, but at least he knew what he was getting into.)

Pulling Permits

When anyone makes a major alteration to a house, they need to pull a permit. Which projects do and don't need a permit varies by city—but adding a structure, plumbing, or any electrical wiring will most likely require one.

However, rule breaking is not uncommon. Not everyone actually *gets* a permit, and this is where things get sticky. If the seller or any prior owner did work on the house without pulling a permit, the new owner will be responsible for getting it up to code. (Yep, that's you.) And not even the code that was applicable when the work was originally done, but the current code, which changes regularly and can vary widely from year to year.

If your city is very strict, that spells extra trouble. In one city just outside of Denver, it's extremely difficult to get permits and work approved, so people like to tiptoe around the rules. If they are caught, they are heavily fined—or in some extreme cases, they're required to remove the improvements and return the house to its previous condition.

Long story short, you must proceed with caution. Let's say your house is in a cookie-cutter 1950s neighborhood and every home on the block has the same exact layout. You notice in your research for comparable home prices that all the neighboring houses have a compartmentalized kitchen, but yours is wonderfully open to the living room. What a steal, right? Unless, that is, that DIY renovator didn't pull a permit or pass an inspection. In that case, knocking down walls for the custom "open concept" kitchen was a violation that you might have to pay to correct.

If you suspect there could have been work done on the home, call your city permit office and ask whether permits were pulled and a Certificate of Occupancy was issued—which means the renovations have passed all inspections. It might *look* like someone converted the detached garage into